

The Beginning of Mark

Mark 1:1-13 as Prologue

When I open a new book, I go straight to the preface, because it is there that I expect to find out what sort of book it is, and why it has been written. And when I write a book, the last thing I write is the preface and introduction, because by then I know what shape the book has taken, and can introduce it in a way which will prepare the reader appropriately for what is to come.

Some of the biblical books seem to have been written in the same way. The first eighteen verses of John's gospel set the scene for what follows not only by introducing John the Baptist and Jesus as the main characters around whom the story will begin, but also by offering a theological framework within which the story can better be understood. Central to that introduction is the creative idea of Jesus as the Word, yet in the rest of the gospel there is no further mention of this idea (compare also the word "grace", of central importance in 1:14, 16, 17, but not used in the rest of the gospel). We have here then, perhaps, John's reflection on the significance of his story of Jesus, written up after the rest of the gospel was finished, using new language which represents the theological conclusions which John wants his readers to share with him.

Mark's gospel does not have such an obviously "theological" introduction, unless it be in the opening verse and in the striking Old Testament quotations which follow (1:2-3, the only such editorial quotation in the whole book). The story seems to begin immediately afterwards with the preaching of John the Baptist, leading directly into the baptism and temptation of Jesus and the beginning of his public activity in Galilee. Yet most commentators these days speak of Mark 1:1-13 (or, more recently, 1:1-15) as Mark's "prologue", and it is frequently suggested that these verses function in much the same way as John 1:1-18.

R. H. Lightfoot pioneered this approach in British scholarship. In a lecture in 1949 he argued against the decision of Westcott and Hort to place a major break in their Greek text of Mark between 1:8 and 1:9, and proposed that Mark 1:1-13 should be treated as Mark's "prologue or introduction", and that "just as in John the narrative proper only begins with the account of the Lord's activity in verses 14 and 15, when he comes into Galilee with the announcement that the time is ripe, and God's promises are now in process of accomplishment".¹

Lightfoot argued his case on the grounds of the content of the passage, rather than by noting more specific linguistic markers. But subsequent study has drawn attention to the fact that, just as John 1:1-18 uses key terms not used in the rest of the gospel, so also does Mark 1:1-13. The terms usually noted are "Spirit" and "wilderness", and

1. R. H. Lightfoot, *The Gospel Message of St. Mark* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1950), p. 19. The argument for 1:1-13 as the prologue takes up pp. 15-20. An important subsequent study reinforcing Lightfoot's at several points was by U. Mauser, *Christ in the Wilderness* (London: SCM, 1963), pp. 77-102.

each of them deserves careful attention.

Spirit

It may seem strange to regard references to the Spirit of God as indicators of a particular theological focus in a given passage. After all, is the Holy Spirit not a frequent subject of attention in the gospels? But in fact it is remarkable that compared with the three very prominent references to the Spirit in 1:8, 10, 12 the rest of Mark's gospel has little to say about the Spirit. The only references are 3:29 (the seriousness of blasphemy against the Holy Spirit), 12:26 (David inspired by the Holy Spirit in the writing of Psalm 110) and 13:11 (the Holy Spirit speaking through the disciples when trial). Only the first of these relates (indirectly) to the role of the Spirit in the ministry of Jesus, whereas in 1:8, 10, 12 the Spirit is a central figure in the launching of that ministry. Here is, apparently, one theological theme to which Mark wants to draw his readers' attention at the outset.

The eschatological outpouring of God's Spirit was an important feature in Old Testament expectation. Peter's quotation of the prophecy of Joel 2:28-32 in his Pentecost sermon (Acts 2:17-21) is a clear indication of this, and other passages include the pouring out of the Spirit from above as one of the blessings of the age to come (Is. 32:15; 44:3; Ezek. 36:26f.; 39:29). This expectation would provide a suggestive background to John the Baptist's prediction of the coming of a "stronger one" who would "baptise (drench) with Holy Spirit" (Mark 1:8). But the other references to the Spirit in Mark's prologue relate not to a general outpouring, but to his specific involvement in the beginning of the ministry of Jesus himself, and here too the Old Testament offered a suggestive background, with the prophecy of the coming "shoot from the stump of Jesse", on whom the Spirit of the Lord would rest (Is. 11:2), and of the Lord's chosen Servant upon whom he has put his Spirit (Is. 42:1), the anointed herald of good news upon whom God's Spirit has come (Is. 61:1).

Thus Mark's emphasis on the role of Spirit in 1:1-13 has the effect of marking Jesus out as the one in whose ministry the hopes of the Old Testament are to come to fulfilment, not only as the one himself empowered and directed by the Spirit for his unique role, but also, remarkably, as the one who himself "dispenses" the Spirit, a function which in the Old Testament passages mentioned above was exclusively that of God himself. There is here, therefore, not only a note of the climax of salvation-history, but also the basis for profound christological reflection. If John the Baptist is the herald of the coming of God to save his people (and that is the clear implication of the quotation of both Mal. 3:1 and Is. 40:3 in Mark 1:2-3),² then who is the "stronger

2. These passages are not "messianic" in the strict sense, in that they do not mention a human agent of God's eschatological work, but only a messenger who directly announces the coming of God himself. In Isaiah 40:3 there is no question of any intermediate figure between the "voice" and the coming of God. In Malachi 3:1 some interpreters would discern a third figure between the "messenger" and the coming of the Lord in judgment. I have argued against this

one" who follows him, and who fulfils God's own promise to pour out his Spirit?

Wilderness

The "voice" of Isaiah 40:3 cries "in the wilderness" (Mark 1:3). It is "in the wilderness" therefore that John the Baptist, the embodiment of that voice, carries out his preaching ministry (1:4), and the wilderness thus constitutes the scene in which Jesus' baptism takes place. Immediately afterwards it is "into the wilderness" that the Spirit directs Jesus (1:12), and, just to make sure that we do not miss the point, Mark reminds us that he was there with Satan and the wild beasts "in the wilderness" (1:13). Since the noun *ἡ ἐρημος* ("the wilderness") occurs nowhere else in Mark's gospel, this looks like a remarkably single-minded attempt by Mark to get his point across.

But what *is* his point? What is so significant about a wilderness?

At the very least, it marks a distinctive location. The rest of Mark's story will be set in the context of normal life, with Jesus surrounded by ordinary people. From time to time he will seek out a quiet place to get away from it all (1:35; 6:31f.), though the crowds will usually manage to find him even there (1:45; 6:33f.). On one memorable occasion he will take three disciples with him onto a lonely hilltop (9:2-8), and there alone in the rest of the gospel will occur a revelation parallel to the one which takes place in the wilderness in 1:10-11. But that will be only a temporary interlude. Here in the prologue, however, Jesus' public activity has not yet begun, and the wilderness represents a separation from ordinary life. With verse 14 the scene will change, and Jesus will be thrust into a ceaseless round of activity among the village of Galilee, but for the moment the crowds are absent, and we can focus on Jesus himself as he faces up alone to the task which lies before him.

But "wilderness" has much more positive significance than just a withdrawal from ordinary life. It is Isaiah's prophecy of the voice in the wilderness which provides the cue for Mark's emphasis on this location, and Mark was not the only person to notice Isaiah's words. It was this same text which provided the rationale for the foundation of the Essene community at Qumran, in that same wilderness of Judaea: "They shall separate from the habitation of ungodly men and shall go into the wilderness to prepare the way of Him; as it is written, 'Prepare in the wilderness the way of the Lord, make straight in the desert a path for our God'" (1QS 8:13f.; cf. 9:19ff.). There *in the wilderness*, not many miles from where John was preaching, the men of Qumran continued to expect that God would appear and vindicate their stand against the apostasy of the official priesthood in Jerusalem.³

interpretation in my *Jesus and the Old Testament* (London: Tyndale, 1971), p. 91, n. 31; an alternative interpretation recently offered by P. A. Verhoef, *The Books of Haggai and Malachi* (New International Commentary on the Old Testament. Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1987), pp. 287-290 still allows no intermediate figure.

3. They were not the only such recluses. Josephus mentions that he spent three years in his youth (mid first-century AD) as the disciple of an ascetic called Bannus who lived the life of a hermit in the wilderness (*Life* 11f.).

For the wilderness was a place of hope, a place of new beginnings.⁴ It was in the wilderness that Yahweh had met with Israel and made them into his people when they came out of Egypt; that was the honeymoon period before the relationship became strained. "I remember the devotion of your youth, your love as bride, how you followed me in the wilderness, in a land not sown. Israel was holy to the Lord, the firstfruits of his harvest" (Jer. 2:2f.). In the wilderness Israel experienced privation and danger, and learned through this testing experience to trust in the provision and protection of their God; this is the message of Moses' great exhortation to Israel in the early chapters of Deuteronomy, summed up especially in Deuteronomy 8 (and used as a model for Jesus' own wilderness experience in the Q version of the Temptation narrative in Matthew 4:1-11; Luke 4:1-13). And so as the prophets looked back to the comparative purity of Israel's wilderness beginnings, the hope grew that in the wilderness God's people would again find their true destiny. "Behold, I will allure her, and bring her into the wilderness, and speak tenderly to her. ... And there she shall answer as in the days of her youth, as at the time when she came out of the land of Egypt" (Hos. 2:14f.; cf. Ezek. 20:35-38). The voice in the wilderness (Is. 40:3-5) which introduces the great vision of restoration in Isaiah 40-55 is followed by the recurrent theme of a new Exodus, a new beginning in a wilderness transformed by the renewing power of Israel's God (Is. 41:18f.; 43:19-21; 44:3f., etc.).⁵

It was this wilderness hope which inspired not only the men of Qumran to go out into the wilderness to wait for God's coming in power, but also several less other-worldly would-be leaders of Israel in the troubled days of the Roman occupation. Theudas, who appears in Acts 5:36, led his followers down to the Jordan (where John had also baptised "in the wilderness"), where they were attacked and routed by the procurator Fadus (Josephus, *Ant.* 20:97f.). Later, under Felix, an Egyptian "prophet" collected a band of freedom-fighters around him in the wilderness before leading them in an ill-fated assault on Jerusalem (Acts 21:38; Josephus, *B.J.* 2:261-3; *Ant.* 20:169-172). Josephus introduces this latter story with a more general mention of "impostors and deceivers" who "called upon the mob to follow them into the desert" (*B.J.* 2:258-260; *Ant.* 20:167f.).⁶ No doubt the remoteness of the location was one good reason for

4. An alternative, and opposite, symbolism is sometimes suggested, that the wilderness is a hostile place, the abode of evil spirits. It is certainly true that it is in the wilderness that Jesus meets with Satan and the wild beasts in Mark 1:12-13, and later Christian tradition developed this idea, as ascetics like St. Antony of Egypt went out into the desert to struggle with demons. Evidence for this idea in Jewish thought is not impressive, however. Reference is usually made to Strack-Billerbeck IV 515f., but in fact at that point Billerbeck simply lists "wilderness and ruins" as one (minor) item in a list of locations attributed to demons, and offers very little evidence, from later rabbinic writings. The intriguing little "story" in Matthew 12:43-45 suggests that the expelled demon did not relish living in "waterless places"!

5. For a much fuller account of the significance of the wilderness in the Old Testament and in subsequent Jewish thought see U. Mauser, *Christ in the Wilderness*, pp. 15-61.

6. Cf. Josephus *B.J.* 7:43f. for a Jewish leader in Cyrene after the Judaeo-Roman War, Jonathan the weaver, who led his followers out into the desert promising them signs and wonders.

such movements to grow up in the wilderness, but at least as important was probably the conviction that the wilderness was (theologically) the right place for a new beginning for the people of God.

So when Mark emphasises the wilderness location in 1:1-13, it is not only in order to signal that this part of the gospel operates on a different level from the story of real-life involvement which will follow, but also because the wilderness is itself a symbol of hope and fulfilment. W. Marxsen makes the point thus: "ἐν τῇ ἐρήμῳ qualifies the Baptist as the fulfiller of OT predictive prophecy. Put in exaggerated form, the Baptist would still be the one who appears 'in the wilderness' even if he had never been there in all his life."⁷ Where else but "in the wilderness" would you expect to see the drama of God's eschatological salvation begin?

A Glimpse Behind the Scenes

What is indicated by the two key words "Spirit" and "wilderness" is spelled out more fully in the content of 1:1-13. Verse 1 prepares us for "good news", and introduces Jesus under two titles calculated to rouse eager expectation, "Messiah" and "Son of God".⁸ Verses 2-3 weave together three prominent Old Testament texts about preparing for the coming of God to judge and save (Mal. 3:1; Ex. 23:20; Is. 40:3). Verses 4-8 present in John's preaching the opening of this new era for God's people, as they repent and receive baptism to mark a new beginning as the forgiven remnant of Israel, but also (and most prominently in Mark's brief account) point forward to a "stronger one" who is to come with a baptism in the Holy Spirit. And then, in fulfilment of that promise, Jesus comes, paradoxically not yet himself dispensing baptism, but rather receiving it as one of the restored community of God's people. But in that moment of identification with the people of God comes a revelation which marks him out as decisively different.

The extraordinary events at Jesus' baptism (Mark 1:10-11) are not presented by Mark as a public declaration about Jesus. He speaks only of what *Jesus* saw, and of a voice from heaven addressed only to him, in the second person. There is nothing in Mark's account, either here or as the story develops, to indicate that anyone else knew about this revelation, and even when the heavenly declaration is repeated (this time in the third person) in 9:7, the audience is limited to the three chosen disciples. So the contents of Mark 1:10-11 are not public property. What Jesus knows as a result of this experience, and what we, the readers, are privileged to share in, remains a secret to all other actors in the story. The recognition of Jesus as the one endowed with the Spirit and declared Son of God by no less an authority than God himself will come to those around

7. W. Marxsen, *Mark the Evangelist* (ET. Nashville: Abingdon, 1969), pp. 37-8.

8. Despite the absence of the phrase "Son of God" from several important witnesses to the text of Mark 1:1, most commentators are cautiously in favour of accepting these words as part of the original text. For a recent example see R. A. Guelich, *Mark 1:1 - 8:16* (Word Biblical Commentary. Dallas: Word Books, 1989), p. 6.

him, even his closest disciples, as a result of bewildering and mind-stretching experiences as the story unfolds, and there will be many misunderstandings and false starts along the way. What Mark has given to us, therefore, is a glimpse behind the scenes, a clue to enable us to understand the story which follows in a way which is not granted to those who will observe the public aspect of Jesus' ministry.

M. D. Hooker expresses this function of Mark's prologue clearly:

These first few verses are a kind of theological commentary on the rest of the narrative. In v. 14 we come down to earth with a bump, the characters in the story become the normal, everyday inhabitants of Galilee. It is as though in vv. 1-13, Mark has allowed us to see Jesus from God's angle, and now the curtain falls, and we are among men and women who stumble around, wondering what is happening. But though the characters in the story are bewildered, Mark does not intend us to forget the truth which he has uncovered in these opening verses.⁹

This function of the prologue has been suggestively compared with that of the first two chapters of the Book of Job, where again a glimpse of the heavenly background enables the reader to gain a perspective which is denied to the actors in the story.¹⁰

This glimpse behind the scenes continues in vv. 12-13, where we are in a situation far from human observation, and Jesus is the only human actor on the stage. With him we find instead supernatural figures, the Spirit, Satan, and the angels. The only other figures on the stage are the wild animals, which probably should be reckoned with Satan as part of the "opposition" rather than, as some of the early fathers proposed, as a symbol of the restoration of Adamic harmony (Gen. 2:18-20).¹¹ We thus have a sort of tableau representing the opposing "sides" which will be involved in the following story, on the one side Jesus with the Spirit and the angels, on the other Satan and the wild animals. A similar tableau is set up in the *Testament of Naphthali* 8:4 (perhaps a Christian interpolation, inspired by Mark 1:12-13, into this Jewish work):

9. M. D. Hooker, *The Message of Mark* (London: Epworth, 1983) p. 16; the whole first chapter of her book is a stimulating non-technical guide to the function of Mark 1:1-12 as prologue.

10. So, e.g., H. Anderson, *The Gospel of Mark* (New Century Bible. London: Oliphants, 1976), p. 63.

11. This patristic interpretation has enjoyed a remarkable revival in several of the more recent commentaries. The idea is not even mentioned in older commentaries such as Gould, Rawlinson and Lohmeyer, and noticed only with hesitation by Taylor, Cranfield and Anderson. It is mentioned only to be dismissed by Haenchen and Lane (following Mauser), but is entertained more positively by Nineham, and has become the central understanding of the mention of the animals in the commentaries of Schweizer, Pesch, Gnllka, Mann and Guelich. To derive this interpretation, as Guelich does (p. 39) from the suggestion that *μετά* with the genitive "indicates that Jesus was living peaceably with the animals" is to read far too much into a simply unmarked preposition, particularly since Guelich refers in support of this claim to *BDF* 227.2, which in fact offers as its first example *πολεμῆν μετά*, "to fight with"! The view that the animals are symbols of evil is effectively argued by E. Best, *The Temptation and the Passion* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1965), pp. 7-9.

If you achieve the good, my children,
 men and angels will bless you;
 and God will be glorified through you among the Gentiles.
 The devil will flee from you;
 wild animals will be afraid of you,
 and the angels will stand by you.¹²

There is in Mark's account of Jesus in the wilderness no story like that of the Q Temptation narrative, indeed no action at all. Jesus simply "is there", being tested, but no outcome to that testing is indicated.¹³ The story will begin in v. 14, when Jesus appears in human society, and people begin to respond to his message. But in vv. 12-13 Mark is still preparing the way, and warning us with this further glimpse behind the scenes that the way ahead will not be easy, that there are issues at stake which will bring Jesus into confrontation with supernatural opposition. He is indeed the Son of God, and comes with the direction and power of the Spirit of God, but there are other forces in the unseen world, and in the story of Jesus of Nazareth we reach the climax of a conflict of eternal dimensions.

Where Does the Story Begin?

The account I have given of Mark's prologue suggests a very clear break between verses 13 and 14. From verse 14 on the Spirit and the wilderness are no longer mentioned; the scene has shifted from the Judaean wilderness to the inhabited towns and villages of Galilee; John the Baptist, a central figure in the prologue, has now been removed from the stage; and the heavenly visions and supernatural actors of verse 10-13 are replaced by everyday scenes peopled by ordinary Galileans. Verses 14-15 introduce the preaching ministry of Jesus which is to be the focus of the chapters that follow. The story has begun.

It seems surprising, therefore, that several of the recent commentaries on Mark designate as the prologue not 1:1-13 but 1:1-15, including in the prologue the verses which I have described as the beginning of the story proper, after the scene has shifted.¹⁴

12. Cf. Ps. 91:11-13, where again angels and animals appear on opposite sides, also in a context of divine protection from evil. The use of this Psalm in the Q Temptation narrative (Matthew 4:6; Luke 4:10-11) forms an intriguing link between the Marcan and Q traditions, though the animals do not feature explicitly in the Q account.

13. E. Best, *The Temptation and the Passion*, pp. 10-15, argues that Mark 3:27 indicates that Satan has already been defeated, and that this must imply that the outcome of the text in 1:12-13 was a victory for Jesus. But 3:27 is in context a statement about Jesus' exorcisms, and indications of the relative power of Jesus and Satan (or the lesser "resident" demon?); as such it does not in itself require 1:12-13 as its basis. The prominence of exorcism in Mark's account suggests to most commentators that he regards the conflict as still in progress after 1:13, not as already finally decided.

14. Commentaries which treat 1:1-15 as the prologue include those of H. Anderson (1976), R. Pesch (1976), J. Gnlika (1978), C. S. Mann (1986), R. A. Guelich (1989).

Up to the mid-seventies Lightfoot's view prevailed, but this alternative approach was inspired by an article by L. E. Keck in 1966,¹⁵ in which he argues that the key word in Mark's introduction is *εὐαγγέλιον*, "gospel", which is "the rubric under which Mark wants to place his material" (p. 359); the occurrence of this word in 1:1 and in 1:14-15 therefore forms the framework of Mark's introduction. He adds the further argument that the repeated mention of John the Baptist in 1:14 serves to round out the account of the relation between John and Jesus which has been developed in 1:7-9. Keck therefore concludes that 1:1-15 forms a rounded introductory paragraph, and the story proper begins with the call of the first disciples in 1:16ff. This then contributes to Keck's proposed analysis of the first half of the gospel into three main sections, each of which begins with "discipleship material" (1:16-20; 3:13-19; 6:7b-13).

As a further development J. Ramsey Michaels¹⁶ has suggested that 1:1-15 was designed in a deliberately chiasmic form, as follows:

- a. the *gospel* of Jesus Christ (v. 1)
 - b. John the Baptist *in the desert*, in fulfilment of Scripture (vv. 2-4)
 - c. John baptizing *in the Jordan* (vv. 5-8)
 - c. Jesus is baptized *in the Jordan* (vv. 9-11)
 - b. Jesus *in the desert* (vv. 12-13)
- a. the *gospel* of God (vv. 14-15)

The scheme certainly draws attention to repeated themes in these opening verses (and the repetition of the wilderness theme is no surprise in the light of our earlier discussion), but proposals for such deliberate patterning of the text are notoriously subjective, and my study of Mark has not so far predisposed me to believe that he was in the habit of designing his work along such lines. Similarly, while Keck is right to observe the recurrence of "discipleship material", it does not therefore follow that the three sections he mentions (and they are not the only sections on "discipleship") are intended to mark the beginning of deliberately composed "sections". Mark's story is notoriously difficult to fit into a convincing structure pattern, and it is likely that, like most good storytellers, he was more concerned to achieve a convincing flow and development of his plot than to encourage detailed structural analysis.

Whether or not verses 14-15 are to be regarded as part of Mark's prologue is therefore probably not ultimately a matter of crucial importance, but I would suggest that this new trend towards designating 1:1-15 as the prologue loses much more than it gains for our appreciation of Mark's introduction to his book. It disguises both the clear shift of scene from the wilderness to Galilee, and, more importantly, the change of focus of which the scene change is a symbol, from the "behind-the-scenes" account of the significance of Jesus to the real life setting of the story of his ministry.

It is, however, helpful to notice that when Mark begins his story in 1:14 he does so in terms which immediately set the story in the context of the themes of the prologue,

15. L. E. Keck, "The Introduction to Mark's Gospel", *NTS* 12 (1965/6), pp. 352-370.

16. J. Ramsey Michaels, *Servant and Son* (Atlanta: John Knox, 1981), p. 44.

by the repeated focus on “good news”, and by the reminder of the relation between John the Baptist and Jesus. The mention of John’s imprisonment serves to move us on from the preliminary setting of John’s active ministry to the predicted arrival of the “stronger one” who now takes over where John has left off. Thus the reader is prepared to see in the story that follows not merely another Baptist, but the Holy Spirit ministry which John has promised, the good news of Jesus the Messiah, the Son of God. What the people of Galilee will gradually begin to perceive is already clear to the reader, and the summary description of Jesus’ new style of ministry in 1:14-15 makes the connection clear. Verses 14-15, rather than rounding out the prologue, form instead a “second introduction”,¹⁷ set now not in John’s wilderness but in the villages of Galilee, for it is in the real-life setting that the good news is to be triumphantly proclaimed, and the kingdom of Satan overthrown.

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17. So J. M. Robinson, *The Problem of History in Mark* (London: SCM, 1957), p. 23.



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